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freeze till 2026. That 50-year-old ice cap is melting now, but with its basic contradiction unresolved. The dysfunctional North, with its runaway population, stands to benefit.

"Delimitation shouldn't reward failure and punish states that met population control targets," says an observer. "This isn't just about numbers—it disincentivises performance. These states reduced fertility, cut maternal mortality, improved women's health. The Centre says the South won't lose out—but what do assurances mean without a methodology in place?"

Fears over shrinking political power are real. The March conclave saw the South ask for the freeze to be extended till 2051. Stalin says the BJP is undermining federalism and accuses the AIADMK of complicity. AIADMK general secretary E.K. Palaniswami counters that Stalin is dangling a red herring. But the absence of a clear word from New Delhi offers the DMK a political opening wrapped up in a policy challenge. ■

Takeaways

- **Home minister Amit Shah makes a splash in TN, predicting a BJP win in 2026. Does not mention delimitation**
- **DMK says it's a sign that BJP plans to prune TN's Lok Sabha seats from 39. Also accuses AIADMK of complicity**

▶ PUNJAB

AAP SEEKS A CHHOTA REFERENDUM

A chance election in Ludhiana West gives the Mann regime an arena in which to test its urban popularity

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

LUDHIANA WEST is voting in a bypoll on June 19 because its last AAP MLA lost his life in a firearm accident. His party, having metaphorically met that fate in the Delhi election, has got more than redemption on its mind. At stake is a seat that captures Punjab's urban pulse, and may shape the narrative for the 2027 assembly election—perhaps even inflect national politics. So AAP, Congress and the BJP are giving it their all.

Each has fielded the strongest available hand. AAP's face, Rajya Sabha MP and Ludhiana-based industrialist Sanjeev Arora, is interesting for another reason. Despite stone-faced denials, the buzz is that if Arora wins, party supremo Arvind Kejriwal may explore a Rajya Sabha route from Punjab. After his low-key retreat from the public eye in the wake of electoral setbacks and legal challenges, such a re-entry could offer Kejriwal a fresh national perch, reviving both visibility and legitimacy.

Even without that angle, Punjab is vital to the party's bid to retain national relevance. A defeat could deepen the sense that AAP is slipping



GOING ALL OUT AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann campaign for Sanjeev Arora (far right) in Ludhiana